

King and Pawn Decisions

Use key squares and opposition, then check the special case of a rook pawn.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 Reach a key square before pushing

P. 3

02 The side to move changes the result

P. 6

03 A rook pawn is a special case

P. 9

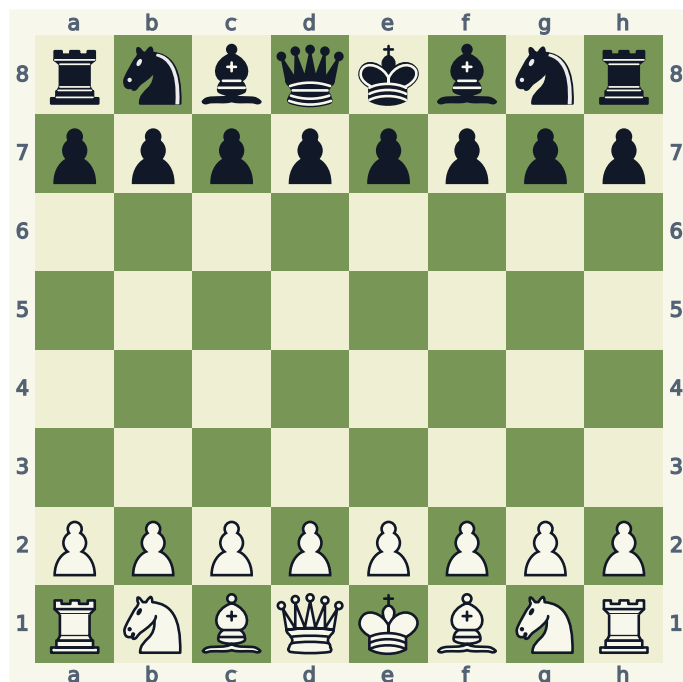
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

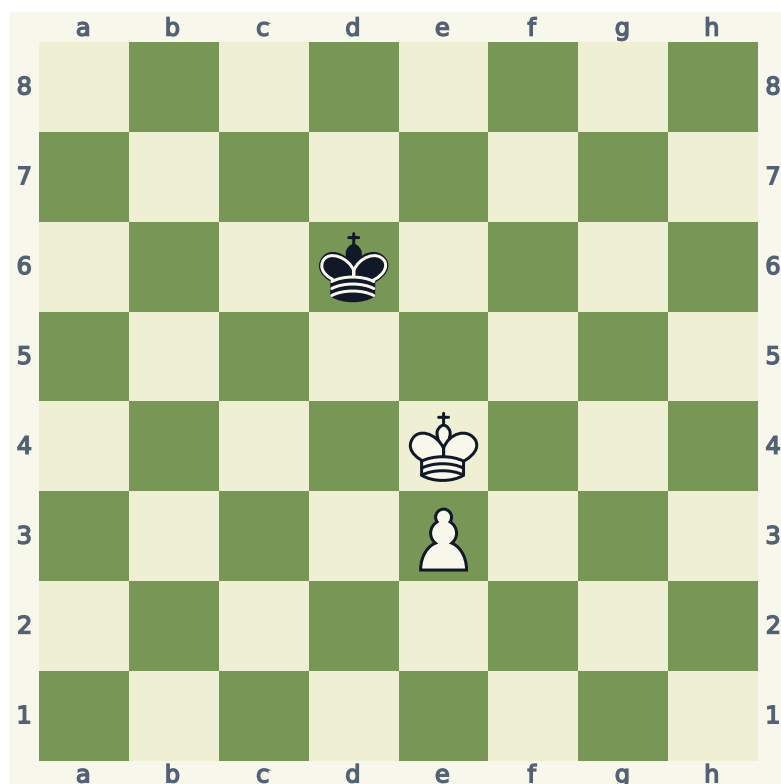
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

Reach a key square before pushing

In a king-and-pawn ending, king placement can be more valuable than a pawn tempo. Key squares tell you where the king needs to stand to force promotion against correct defense.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. For this white e3-pawn, the key squares are d5, e5 and f5.
2. Kf5 reaches a key square because Black's king on d6 does not attack f5.
3. The pawn is still on e3; pushing it changes the key-square problem.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Kf5 Ke7 2. Ke5

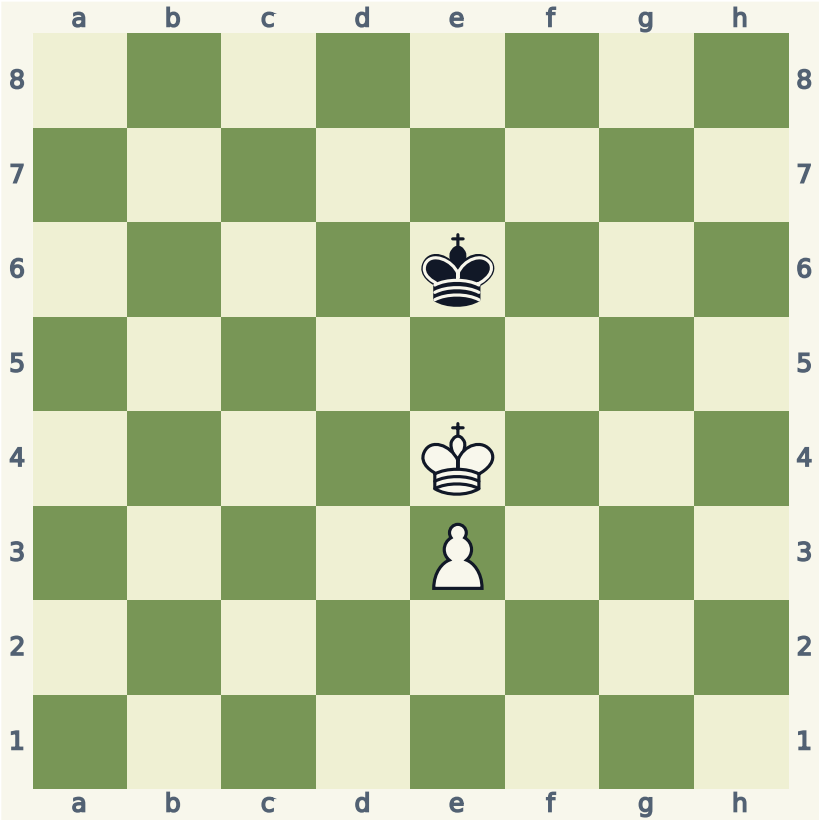
Kf5 reaches a winning king position. After the sample ...Ke7, Ke5 keeps the king in front of the pawn and takes the opposition. The exact starting position and this continuation are tablebase wins for White.

Do not immediately play e4 after ...Ke7. That move uses a pawn tempo before the king has secured the next stage; Black can hold the resulting position. The king must continue doing the work instead of assuming that reaching one key square makes every later pawn push safe.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



1. Which black king move in the setup has changed White's access to f5 and d5?
2. Can White force a win from this exact position?
3. Follow Kd4 ...Kd6 e4 ...Ke6. What has Black maintained?

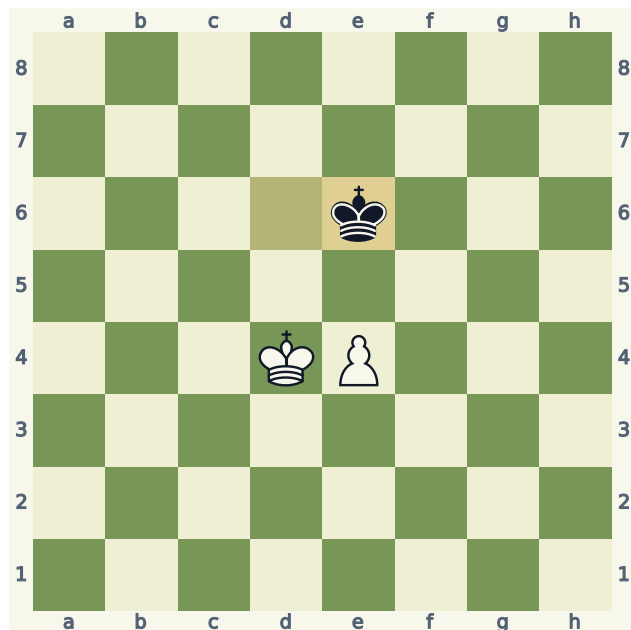
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 8/8/4k3/8/4K3/4P3/8/8 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Kd4 Kd6 2. e4 Ke6

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. Black's king is now on e6. It controls d5, e5 and f5, so White cannot move directly onto any of the e3-pawn's key squares.

2. No. With White to move this is a tablebase draw against correct defense. White can still try, but a plan must not promise a forced promotion that the position does not contain.

3. Black stays in front of the pawn and responds to White's king and pawn moves without allowing penetration. The sample line remains drawn at every step. The exercise tests recognition of a defensive resource, not the search for a nonexistent winning move.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

For an ordinary pawn on its second, third or fourth rank, the three key squares are two ranks ahead on its file and adjacent files. Rook pawns are a special case, and advanced pawns use different key squares. Do not apply this limited rule everywhere.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

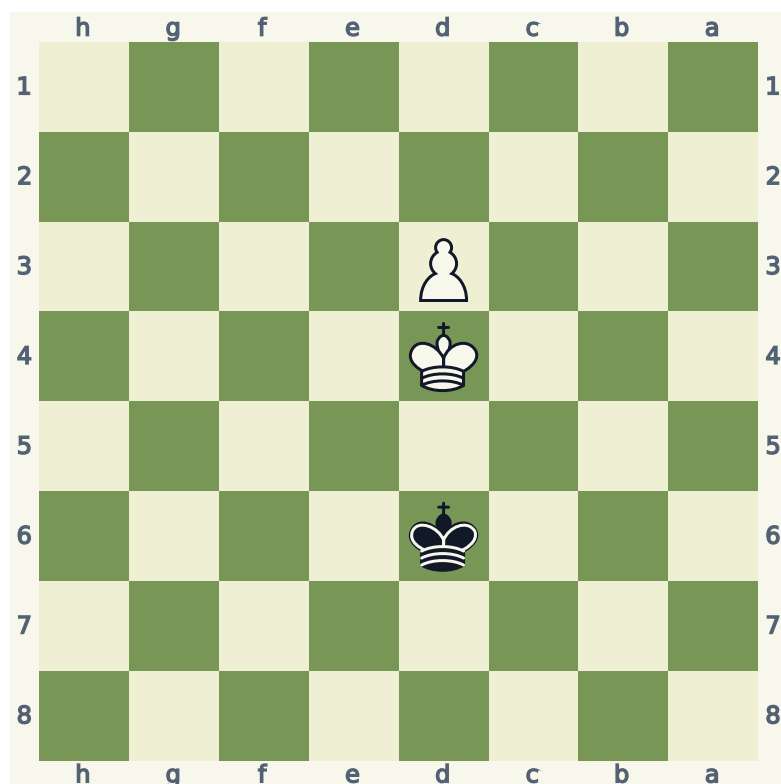
Play both starting positions against a tablebase. Before each pawn push, stop and predict whether the result stays a win or draw; then check the answer.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

The side to move changes the result

Opposition is a way to control access, not a magic label. With kings facing each other one square apart, the player forced to move may have to yield a route around the other king.

MODEL A / BLACK TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. The kings stand on d4 and d6, separated by d5.
2. It is Black to move in Model A.
3. White's d3-pawn is still behind its king, leaving the king room to advance.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1... Kc6 2. Ke5 Kd7 3. Kd5

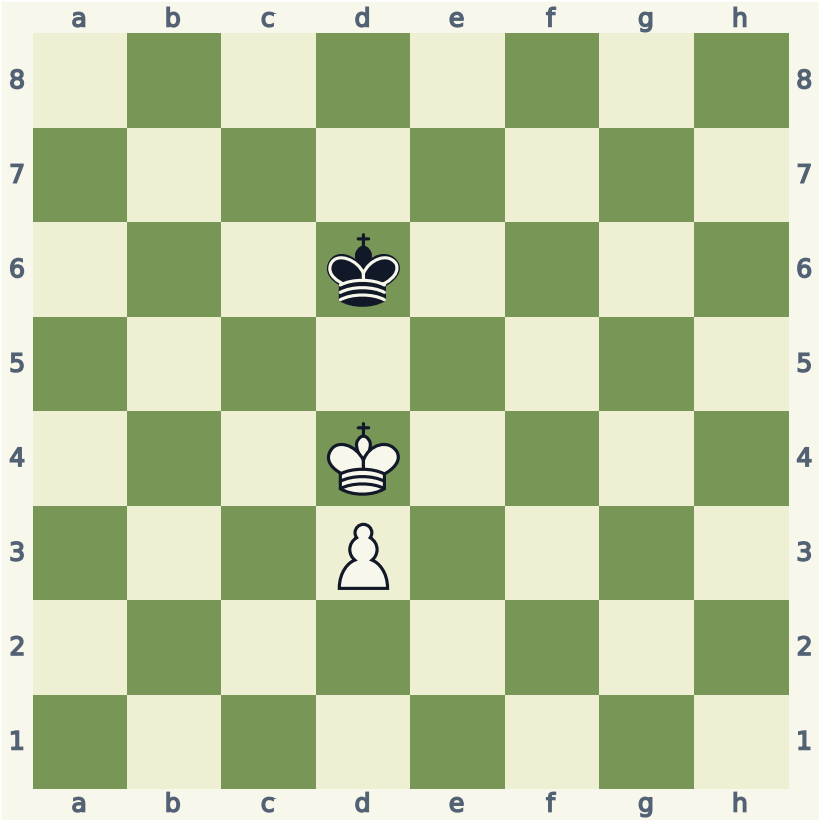
Black must yield ground. After ...Kc6, Ke5 reaches a key square for the d3-pawn. Following ...Kd7, Kd5 keeps the king in front and preserves the win.

Do not replace Kd5 with an automatic d4 push. In that exact position, d4 gives up the win and allows a draw. Opposition helps the king gain access; you still have to choose moves that keep the access useful as the pawn advances.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. What is the only change from Model A?
- 2. State the correct result with best play.
- 3. After Kc4, how does ...Kc6 help Black, and what is the sample continuation?

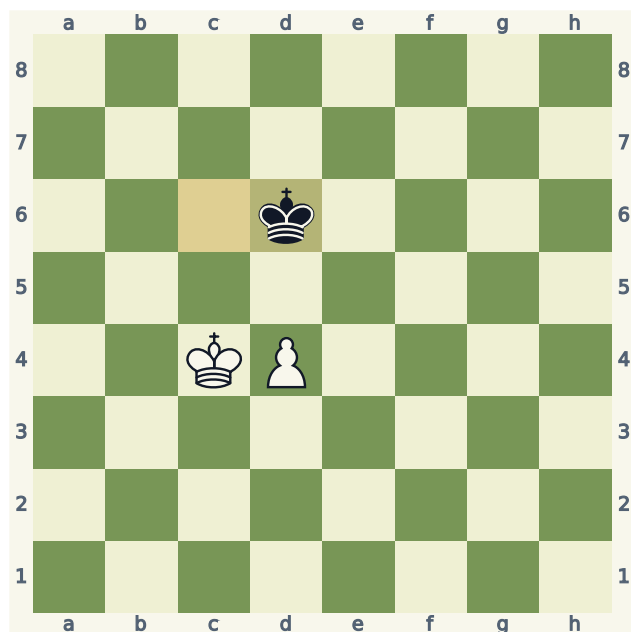
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 8/8/3k4/8/3K4/3P4/8/8 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Kc4 Kc6 2. d4 Kd6

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The pieces occupy exactly the same squares, but White moves first. The side-to-move label is part of the position, not a minor caption.

2. This version is a draw. In Model A, Black to move loses; here White must move away from the favorable king opposition and cannot force penetration.

3. ...Kc6 keeps Black in front of White's king. After d4, ...Kd6 holds the blockading relationship. The listed line stays drawn. Learn the route and the move order instead of memorizing a picture without its turn.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

A pawn move can alter who must move the king next. Count available pawn tempi and the actual key squares; having "the opposition" is not a substitute for calculating the resulting position.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

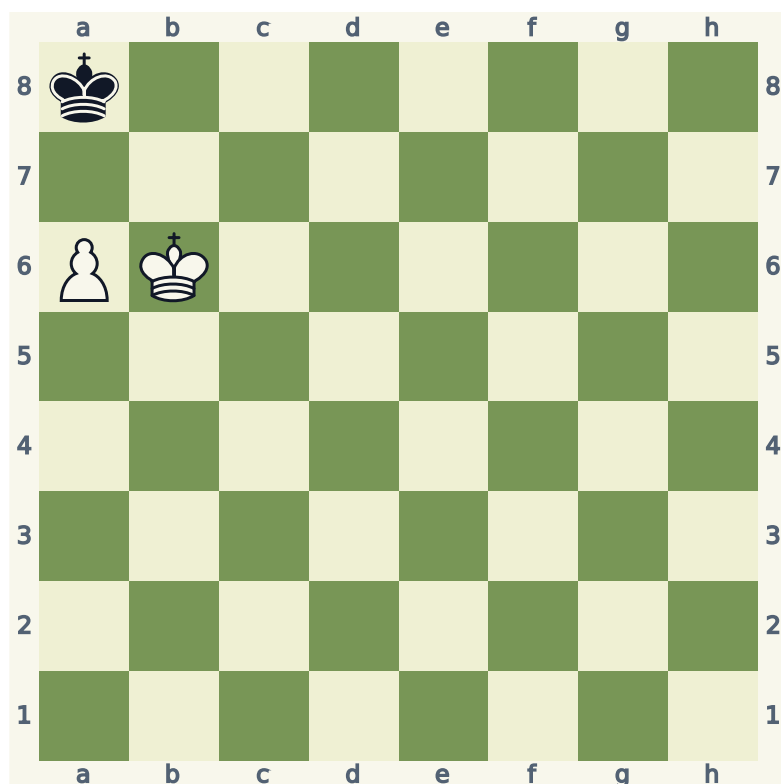
Set up the same diagram twice and alternate who moves first. Predict the result before checking a tablebase, then explain the route the attacker gains or loses.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

A rook pawn is a special case

A rook pawn often draws when the defending king reaches the promotion corner. There is no second side for the attacking king to work around, and stalemate limits attempts to force the defender out.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's a6-pawn promotes on a8, occupied by Black's king.
2. White's king on b6 cannot force Black out of that corner.
3. If White plays a7, Black is not checked and has no legal move.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. Kc7 Ka7 2. Kc6 Ka8

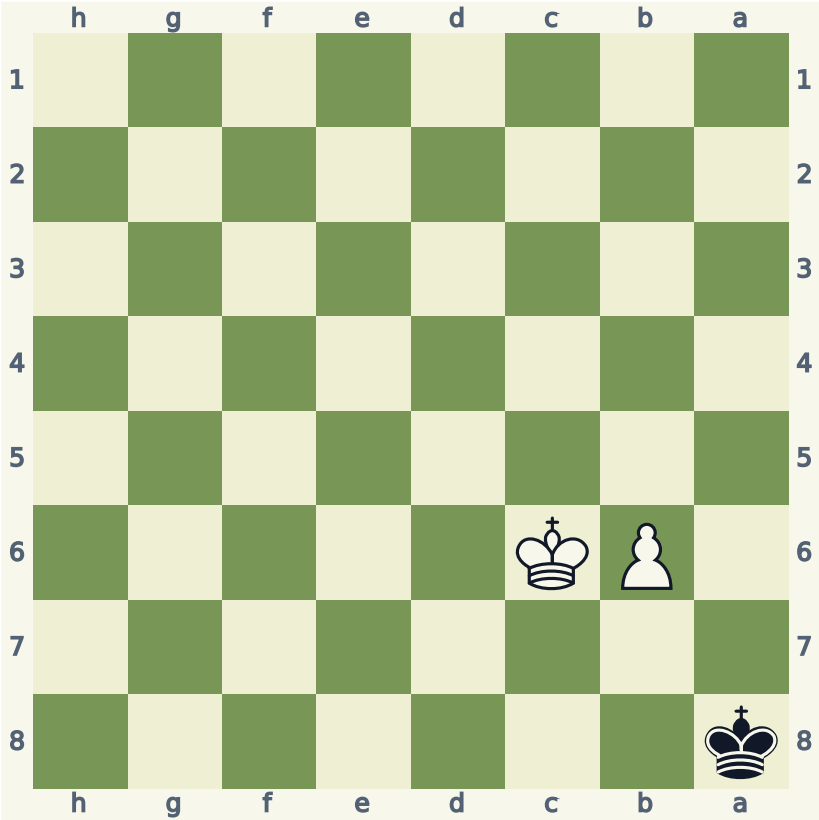
Kc7 ...Ka7 Kc6 ...Ka8 shows the defender retaining the corner without losing. The exact starting position is a tablebase draw, not a failed search for a hidden winning move.

The tempting a7 is immediate stalemate: a7 is occupied by the pawn and defended by the king, b7 is controlled by White's king, and b8 is controlled by the pawn. Black is not in check on a8. Waiting moves do not create an extra file around the board's edge.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / BLACK TO MOVE



- 1. It is Black to move here. What is Black's only legal move?
- 2. Give White's winning route through promotion after that move.
- 3. If White moved first in this same diagram instead, would Kc7 win?

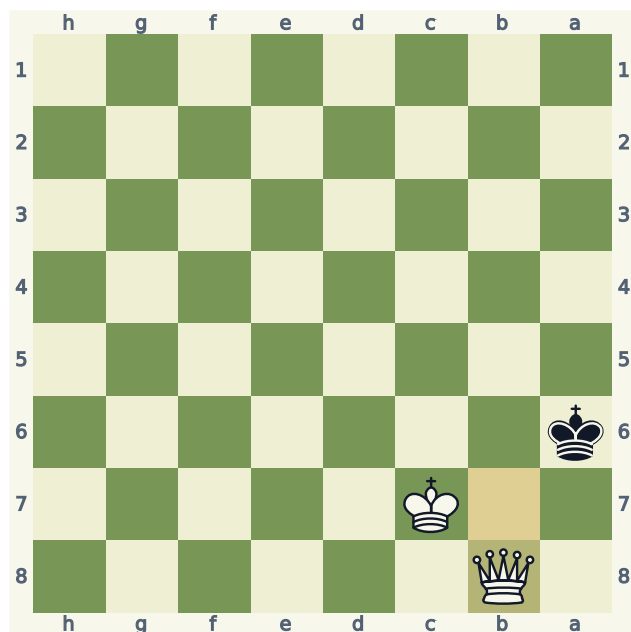
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): k7/8/1PK5/8/8/8/8 b - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1... Kb8 2. b7 Ka7 3. Kc7 Ka6 4. b8=Q

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. Black must play ...Kb8. The pawn on b6 attacks a7, and White's king controls b7. Unlike the rook-pawn case, this forced exit allows White to promote with correct play.

2. After ...Kb8, b7 ...Ka7 Kc7 ...Ka6 b8=Q promotes. Black can choose other replies after the pawn push, but all lose with correct play. The tablebase confirms that this starting position with Black to move is lost for Black.

3. No. With White to move, Kc7 would be stalemate: the b6-pawn attacks a7, and the king on c7 controls b7 and b8. In fact the White-to-move version is drawn with best defense. Pawn file and side to move both matter.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

A non-rook pawn offers different geometry, but stalemate still matters. Do not assume that every king move in a winning position preserves the win.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

Replace a rook pawn with a b-pawn while preserving a legal position. Before every move, list the defending king's legal squares and whether the pawn gives check.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. Why can an early pawn push spoil a won king-and-pawn ending?
2. Can changing only the side to move change a pawn ending from win to draw?
3. Why must you read the side-to-move label even in the b-pawn example?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. It can spend a needed tempo and move the key squares before the king secures the next stage.
2. Yes. It can force the wrong king to yield a key route or consume a vital tempo.
3. Black to move must yield with ...Kb8 and loses; White to move cannot force a win and Kc7 is stalemate.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

[Lichess practice: tactics and endgames](#)

[Lichess opposition practice](#)

[Lichess basic rook endgames](#)

[Stockfish: official engine](#)

[Lichess tablebase API](#)

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: 1d42c4. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.